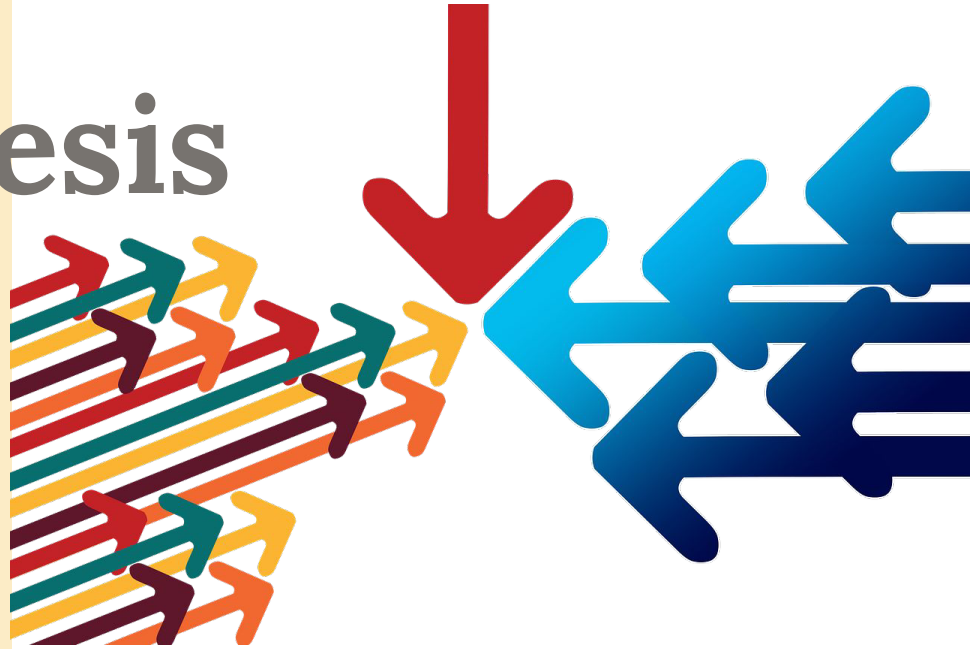


# Lesson 3: Thesis statement

HS192 Introduction to Writing - 2  
@ IITGN, 2025-26



Today's first learning objective

**Determine and evaluate the  
elements of central claims of  
argumentative writing pieces.**

# Argumentative writing

“The argumentative essay is a genre of writing that requires the student to **investigate** a topic; collect, generate, and evaluate evidence; and **establish** a position on the topic in a concise manner.”

"Argumentative Essays." *Purdue Online Writing Lab*. [Online]. Available: [https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general\\_writing/academic\\_writing/essay\\_writing/argumentative\\_essays.html/](https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/academic_writing/essay_writing/argumentative_essays.html/) [Accessed: Jan. 6, 2024].

“An argumentative essay [...] uses **factual evidence** and **logical support** to convince the reader of a certain way of thinking.

M. Ellis, "How to Write a Standout Argumentative Essay." *Grammarly*, Jun. 2, 2022. [Online]. Available: <https://www.grammarly.com/blog/argumentative-essay/> [Accessed: Jan. 6, 2024].

# Do you remember “thesis statement”?

What role does a thesis statement play in the writing?

It presents the central claim or main argument of the written work.

It acts as a guide throughout the work to keep the unified focus.

What does a thesis statement consist of?

**Topic**

**Controlling idea**

# Where does a thesis statement appear?

Which types of writing need a thesis statement?

Academic essays and scholarly papers.

Even emails need a thesis statement to deliver a clear message!

In an essay, where is a thesis statement located?

After a hook and before the main (detailed) body

Most likely within the first few sentences, or at most, within the first two paragraphs

# What is thesis statement?

- A thesis statement displays the **core message** and central idea for the essay.
- It states the purpose of the essay and acts as a **guide** for the rest of the essay.
- It provides an overview of all that **key points** that will be discussed in the main body.

Topic



Controlling idea

# Structure of thesis statement: **Topic**

Under the mission of writing about “my passion/excellence”

What do I have **passion** for?

Helping neighbors

What **skills** do I have?

Playing cricket

What **achievement** have I made?

Watching Netflix series

Writing blog posts

# Structure of thesis statement: Controlling idea

Controlling idea provides the direction of elaboration

Helping neighbors

**So, what  
about  
the topic  
do you  
want to  
talk  
about?**

helped me grow as a cooperative  
and responsible person.

Playing cricket

shaped my childhood with lessons  
of teamwork and perseverance.

Watching Netflix series

got me out of slump. With it, I also  
discovered various other cultures.

Writing blog posts

Has been my lifelong passion. It  
heals my days and gives creativity.



# Quality of good claims



Arguable



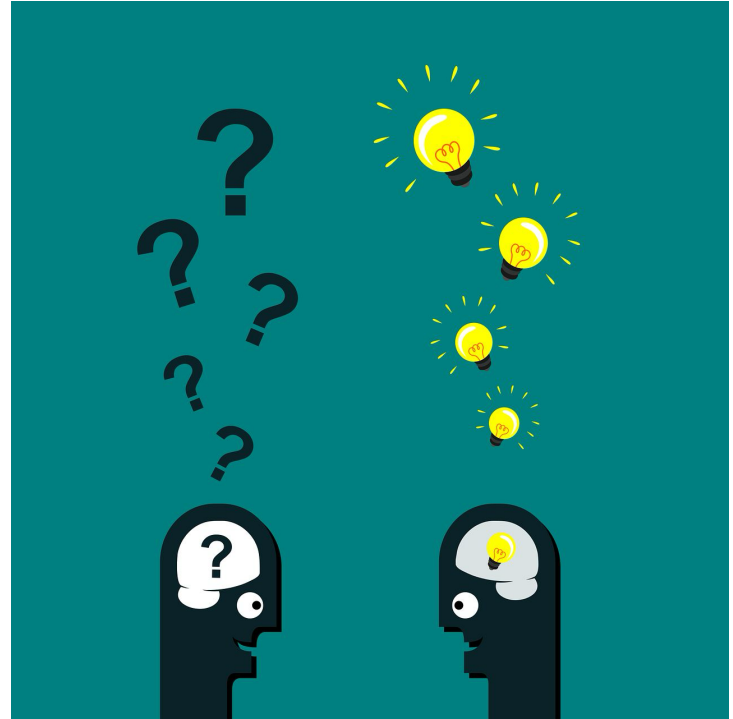
Specific



Meaningful



Reasonable



# ASMR

A good claim is **arguable** in the sense that someone would be able to argue against the claim(s).

Why?

- The point of argumentative writing is to prove your specific insight.
- If the thesis can't be argued against, your writing will be uninteresting.

**Is it a contestable claim? “Gujarati foods are sweet.”**

Why or why not? What possible contestable theses can you make about Gujarati foods?

# ASMR

A good claim is **specific**.

- Broad and vague claims are difficult to support.
- Your argument will be more engaging with specific claims and supporting evidence.
- Specific details provide a 'why' to the claim and thus help direct your supporting.

**Using general adjectives like *good*, *bad*, and *interesting* is avoided for a claim. Is it a specific claim? “Winter is fun”**

Why or why not? How could we make a specific claim on the winter season?



A good claim is **meaningful** in the sense that it addresses points that are worth discussing. The author as well as the reader should see a value in discussing the points. We can ask ourselves such questions:

- Is the topic related to the claim meaningful to discuss?
- Does the discussion on the claim benefit me (personal level) or my community (societal level)?

**Is this claim meaningful? “Based on the recent surge of visitors to the medical center, hostel residents may need a systematic help to endure the coldness in January”**

Why or why not? Could we make a meaningful claim to you or your group?



A good claim is **reasonable** because it is supposed to persuade the reader.

- A reasonable claim must make sense.
- Evidence must exist to support the claim.
- Relevant facts must align to the claim.

**Is it a reasonable claim? “Summer is better than winter in IIT Gandhinagar because everyone is leaving campus.”**

Why or why not? What possible reasonable claims can you make about the season of Gandhinagar?

# How many claims does an argumentative thesis statement have?

Argumentative writing expresses one or more claim.

It depends on the number of central points you want to make.

In a short writing, the thesis is simple (one point); otherwise, it can be complex (two or more points).

The number of central points may be determined by the given word limit; or, it determines the the length of your writing when there is no word limit.

# Group activity



1. Read the one of the following Amazon reviews

- Group 1, 4 & 7: [Review A](#)
- Group 2, 5 & 8: [Review B](#)
- Group 3, 6 & 9: [Review C](#)



2. Find the main claim or thesis statement.

3. Determine whether or not the thesis is arguable, specific, meaningful, and reasonable. Why?



| Arguable                                            | Specific                        | Meaningful                    | Reasonable                              |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Does the claim acknowledge multiple points of view? | Does the claim provide details? | Is the thesis meaningful at ? | Does the presented argument make sense? |

# Debrief

Which element within the central claims or thesis identification chart do you find most helpful in evaluating the thesis?

How might you have improved this thesis statement?



Today's second learning objective

**Analyze the elements of a  
complex thesis or central  
claims**

# A complex thesis or central claim

A complex thesis will have more than one point to prove. Both a simple and a complex thesis will be arguable, reasonable, specific, and interpretive.

How many claims does it have? What should the author prove in the essay?

Social media provides great tools for free education.

Although social media promotes cost-free education, it often distract learners by spreading misinformation and addictive contents.

# Identification of controlling ideas

Social media provides great tools for free education.

The simple thesis statement must prove one thing. In this case, the writer must prove how the education system prepares students for college.

Although social media promotes cost-free education, it often distract learners by spreading misinformation and addictive contents.

The complex thesis statement must prove many things (highlighted in pink).

# Analysis of a complex thesis

Although social media promotes cost-free education, it often distract learners by spreading misinformation and addictive contents.

The complex thesis statement must prove many things:

- How does social media provide cost-free education for students?
- Define 'learners' and 'distract'.
- Does learners' distraction take place often?
- What are the cases of misinformation and how impactful they are?
- What are the cases of addiction and how impactful they are?

# Things that are not a thesis

**Fact:** Colleges require high scores on their entrance exams.

**General statement:** Good deeds always return.

**Heads-up:** This essay will discuss why primary schools must focus on character education.

**Question:** In the current crisis of another wave of COVID, what preparations should India make?

# Group activity

Fact, general statement, heads-up, simple thesis, or complex thesis?

1. Primary school is a part of the educational journey.
2. Students' attitude in the classroom reflects their performance in the exam.
3. How does successful secondary education affect college entrance?
4. Secondary education is required for college entrance.
5. Although students' attitude in class is important for their learning, the exam result is often more dependent on their practice outside of the classroom.
6. This paper will demonstrate the importance of excelling in school.

# Debrief

What was easy to identify? What was difficult?

What other examples of simple thesis can we make?

What other examples of complex thesis can we make?